

WA.3 Inspection Sequence

The order Washington inspections happen in, which agency you call for each one, the three tests you have to pass, and a log to record every result as you go.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Washington's building code is written by the State and enforced locally by 39 counties and hundreds of cities and towns, each with its own forms and fees — and your electrical permit may come from a different agency altogether. Confirm every item with the department that will issue your permit before you rely on it. Your permit card lists the inspections your job requires — it governs.

YOU WILL BE CALLING TWO DIFFERENT AGENCIES

This is the single thing that catches owner-builders in Washington, and it is not difficulty — it is a phone book problem. Your **building, plumbing and mechanical** inspections come from the city or county that issued your building permit. Your **electrical** inspections almost certainly do not.

The residential code hands electrical work straight out of the building department: *"Electrical Code is regulated by chapter 296-46B WAC or Electrical Code as adopted by the local jurisdiction."* Chapter 296-46B WAC is the Department of Labor & Industries' rule book. The statute behind it is blunter still — L&I's director *"shall cause an inspector to inspect all wiring, appliances, devices, and equipment to which this chapter applies,"* and *"nothing contained in this chapter may be construed as providing any authority for any subdivision of government to adopt by ordinance any provisions contained or provided for in this chapter except those pertaining to cities and towns."*

Cities and towns, not counties

The local-electrical-program option belongs to **incorporated cities and towns**. A city or town may enact and enforce its own electrical ordinance to an equal, higher or better standard, and where it does, its inspectors must meet the same qualifications as state electrical inspectors. Counties have no such power under this chapter.

So: if your lot is in unincorporated county, your electrical permit and inspections come from **L&I**. If you are inside city limits, ask the city whether it runs its own electrical program — several of the larger ones do. Settle this before you pull any permit; it decides who you call for the rest of the job. (RCW 19.28.010(3), (4); RCW 19.28.101(1))

Two rights on the electrical side you are unlikely to be told about

A 48-hour commitment. *"Upon request, electrical inspections will be made by the department within forty-eight hours, excluding holidays, Saturdays, and Sundays."*

And a remedy if they miss it. *"If, upon **written** request, the electrical inspector fails to make an electrical inspection within twenty-four hours, the serving utility may immediately connect electrical power to the installation if the necessary electrical work permit is displayed."* Note the word **written** — a phone call does not start this clock. If you are waiting on temporary power, put the request in writing and keep the copy. (RCW 19.28.101(2))

THE SEQUENCE — AND WHO YOU CALL FOR EACH

The order below is the common Washington residential sequence. The exact list for your job, and how your department bundles the trades, is printed on your permit card — that is the list that governs. What is **not** negotiable is the agency column, and the rule that nothing gets covered before it is approved.

Common Washington residential sequence — and the agency for each call

Inspection	What must be complete / what is verified	Who
1. Temporary power	Service pole or temporary service for construction. Requires an electrical work permit, and the utility may not connect until the installation is approved.	L&I or city
2. Footing / setback	Trenches excavated, forms and reinforcing steel in place, before any concrete is placed. Many jurisdictions verify setbacks at this visit — have your site plan on site.	City / county
3. Foundation and under-slab	Foundation walls, damp-proofing and drainage; and everything the slab will bury — under-slab plumbing, vapor retarder, any under-slab conduit. Radon rough-in is inspected here where it applies.	City / county
4. Under-floor / crawl space	Piers, girders, sill anchorage, grade clearances and ground cover in a crawl space. If you have chosen an unvented crawl space, this is where the radon provisions you opted into show up.	City / county
5. Shear wall / nailing	Called separately in much of western Washington because of the seismic design category: hold-downs, anchor bolts, shear panel edge nailing and the continuous load path, before anything covers them.	City / county
6. Electrical rough-in (cover)	All wiring in place before it is concealed. This is a separate call to a separate agency and it is the one most likely to be forgotten — nothing may be covered until the electrical inspector approves it.	L&I or city

Common Washington residential sequence — and the agency for each call

Inspection	What must be complete / what is verified	Who
7. Plumbing and mechanical rough-in	Water, waste and vent piping under test, gas piping, duct runs and combustion air, before concealment.	City / county
8. Framing	After roof cover, with framing, blocking, bracing and firestopping complete and all rough-ins approved. Commonly the visit where the building inspector checks that every other rough-in has signed off.	City / county
9. Insulation and air sealing	Insulation and air barrier in place, before wall and ceiling covering. The energy code's installation criteria are inspected here.	City / county
10. Duct leakage test	Rough-in or post-construction, by the tester — see the thresholds below. A signed written report goes to the code official.	Third-party tester
11. Septic pre-cover	The system may not be backfilled until the local health officer has given approval to cover. Different agency again.	Local health
12. Blower door and ventilation verification	Both mandatory, both after the envelope is closed. Signed written reports to the code official.	Third-party tester
13. Final electrical	Required before the utility will connect permanent power.	L&I or city
14. Final plumbing, mechanical, and building	The building final is the one that releases the certificate of occupancy.	City / county

*The agency split is statutory: WAC 51-51-003; RCW 19.28.101(1), (5); RCW 19.28.010(3), (4). The septic cover approval is WAC 246-272A-0250(3)(g). The three tests are WAC 51-11R-40240, WAC 51-11R-40320 and WAC 51-11R-40350. The **order and bundling** of the building-side calls is set by your jurisdiction under the administrative provisions of the adopted International Residential Code — this kit prints the common sequence rather than model-code subsection numbers, because your permit card is the list that binds you. Verified August 2026.*

THE THREE TESTS — BOOK THEM EARLY

Washington does not offer a visual alternative to any of these. All three produce a signed written report that goes to the code official, and in rural counties there are few testers, so they set your schedule rather than the other way round.

Mandatory performance tests, 2021 Washington State Energy Code

Test	What it requires	Section
Envelope air leakage (blower door)	<i>"The building or dwelling unit shall be tested for air leakage."</i> Maximum 4.0 air changes per hour at 50 Pa for any dwelling unit under any compliance path . The report must carry a verified location and time stamp and be signed by the testing agency.	§ R402.4.1.2 § R402.4.1.3.1
Duct leakage	Rough-in: 4.0 cfm per 100 sq ft of conditioned floor area at 25 Pa — or 3.0 if the air handler is not yet installed. Post-construction: 4.0 cfm per 100 sq ft. Ducts and air handlers entirely inside the thermal envelope: 8.0 — but ducts in a crawl space do not qualify .	§ R403.3.5 § R403.3.6
Ventilation airflow	<i>"Mechanical ventilation systems shall be tested and verified to provide the minimum ventilation flow rates required."</i> The one owner-builders forget, because it does not feel like a test. Ducted range hoods of 6 inches or larger with no more than one elbow are excepted.	§ R403.6.2

WHEN AN INSPECTION GOES WRONG

Failures, concealment, and power

Situation	What applies	Authority
You failed a building inspection	Get the written correction notice, fix exactly what it names, and re-call. Re-inspection fees and how soon you may re-call are local — ask at your first inspection so it is not a surprise at your fifth.	local
You failed an electrical inspection	A different regime. Where an installation is not in accordance with the chapter or is dangerous, you are notified and <i>"shall within fifteen days, or such further reasonable time as may upon request be granted,"</i> make the repairs. The inspector may order electrical service disconnected, and reconnecting without approval is unlawful.	RCW 19.28.101(3)
You covered something early	<i>"No electrical wiring or equipment subject to this chapter may be concealed until it has been approved by the inspector making the inspection."</i> At inspection it must be sufficiently accessible for the inspector to test it. Expect to open it up. The same principle applies to your septic system and to every building-side rough-in.	RCW 19.28.101(4)
The utility will not connect you	You must obtain inspection and approval from L&I <i>"before requesting the electric utility to connect."</i> The utility connects on the certified permit. If an inspection is overdue, use the written-request route in RCW 19.28.101(2).	RCW 19.28.101(5)

At the end, the building department issues the certificate of occupancy under the administrative provisions of the adopted International Residential Code. Ask yours early what it wants in hand before it will issue — commonly every trade final including the electrical one, the energy test reports, and the septic operational approval. Do not plan a move-in date around an assumption here.

INSPECTION LOG — RECORD EVERY ONE

Fill this in as it happens, not from memory. Note **which agency** you called as well as the result — on a Washington job that is the detail you will want six months later. If a result is ever disputed, this page and your photographs are the record you have.

Inspection log

Inspection	Agency	Called	Held	Result	Corrections required / notes
Temporary power					
Footing / setback					
Foundation / under-slab					
Under-floor / crawl					
Shear wall / nailing					
Electrical rough-in					
Plumbing rough-in					
Mechanical rough-in					
Framing					
Insulation / air sealing					
Duct leakage test					
Septic pre-cover					
Blower door					
Ventilation verification					
Final electrical					
Final plumbing					

Inspection log

Inspection	Agency	Called	Held	Result	Corrections required / notes
Final mechanical					
Final building					

Certificate of occupancy issued: _____ Number: _____

Sources (verified August 2026 at app.leg.wa.gov). Electrical is inspected by L&I and no subdivision of government may legislate in the field except cities and towns — RCW 19.28.101(1) with RCW 19.28.010(3), (4). The 48-hour inspection commitment and the 24-hour written-request remedy — RCW 19.28.101(2). Fifteen days to correct after notice, and disconnection powers — RCW 19.28.101(3). Nothing concealed before approval, and accessibility at inspection — RCW 19.28.101(4). No utility connection before approval — RCW 19.28.101(5). The residential code sends electrical to chapter 296-46B WAC or the local jurisdiction's electrical code — WAC 51-51-003. Blower door, duct and ventilation testing — WAC 51-11R-40240, 51-11R-40320, 51-11R-40350 (2021 Washington State Energy Code, Residential, effective March 15, 2024). Septic may not be covered before the local health officer approves — WAC 246-272A-0250(3)(g).